UK Data Service

Pioneers

of Qualitative Research

Jonathan Gershuny

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2017

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Jonathan Gershuny

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

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1: Self-launching from a Jewish Migrant Family

My father was the son of a Jewish immigrant from Russia, who settled, who had the misfortune to arrive in the UK on the day that the First World War broke out, was conscripted into the English Army eventually. He was a watch-maker who worked in a jeweller's shop, married the shopkeeper's daughter. In the East End of London, living in Shoreditch. And then acquired a rudimentary training as an optician, set up an optician's shop, and my father was born in 1921, in London. He had a slightly more formal training. He went to the Northampton Institute, which is now City University, where **John Bunn (?? - 1.23)** was. He did an optics training there and acquired this wonderful title, "Fellow of the Worshipful Company of Spectacle Makers", which was the professional qualification. And City turns it into a B.Sc. But basically he was very proud of this London connection.

Having had his training, he went into the Navy as an Ordinary Seaman. Around the time of "Lend Lease" they needed new Naval officers, so people with a degree level physics training got absorbed into fast-track temporary gentleman type training. Then he was on minesweepers. And he actually really identified. He insisted on going into the Navy, and he really identified himself as a seaman, and then as a Naval officer ...

My mother, my birth mother was a year or two older than my father. She had done an English degree in UC, in the late thirties. At UC, University College in London. And was a civil servant. They married in '48, I was born in '49.

And where was your father's family from originally?

About 50 miles south of Riga. My grandmother always said Latvia… Her family left in 1887, when, of course, it was all a Russian Province, and they were Russian and Yiddish speaking. The Hebrew Yiddish name for the entire Baltic area was, was "Lettow", which she

translated Lithuania, so I always said I came from Lithuania, where, in fact, I probably didn't!

So your mother's family were from?

And my mother's family were more settled in the UK. My grandfather was a jeweller in Margate, called "Israel Eichenbaum". So my middle name is Israel. I was always told that it was to celebrate the formation of the state, but in fact it was my maternal grandfather's first name. And I was brought up in a Jewish household. My mother, tragically, when she fell pregnant, discovered she had cervical cancer, refused to have any treatment until I was born, but then had five years of misery, which made for a strange childhood for me.

So was she able to look after you?

She wasn't really, and I was shunted between relatives which had all sorts of strange consequences. I suspect that my face blindness, for example, may come from the fact that I didn't acquire the habit of recognising faces because I was being passed around as a very small child. That's speculation, I've never looked properly into it. I was obviously an only child. My father remarried when I was five, and suddenly, to my great joy, I acquired a brother - a brother even though he was a stepbrother - and then subsequently a half-brother.
So then I was back in a family fold, and brought up in North London. We lived in Wembley. It's probably indicative that having had my first jobs in Brighton and in Bath, we set up a family home in Wembley, not half a mile from my parents, back in 1987, and we're living there still.
I went to the local primary schools, and then I went to a posh Direct Grant school, as they were called then, called "Haberdashers Aske School" in North London. And both my brothers went there as well. I was a terrible, terribly badly behaved school child, I have to say. I was detached. I'd become extremely bookish, and basically I was beastly to my teachers. I always considered that I'd read more than they had, which was, in some cases, certainly true! But I'd acquired various sorts of – not - "disability" is quite the wrong word. Various bad habits in primary school, so I was told that I couldn't read the next book until I'd written a report on it. I would just read all the books and never write reports! That was the start of my bad school behaviour that basically lasted until right the way through my entirely undistinguished undergraduate period, when I did an Economics, Politics, and Sociology degree. I knew, ahead of time, that I wanted to be an academic.

But when you say "bad behaviour", reading lots of books doesn't sound like bad behaviour to me.

Yes, but not doing homework - "The dog ate it, sir"! Eventually, because my school was actually in Elstree, which at this time was effectively outside London, I was systematically late, which meant I missed the coaches which then took the children from North London Underground stations to the grand Elstree establishment. So I'd take buses and then walk up the country lanes and arrive.

And why were you doing that?

Because I hated it. Because it was purgatory. Because it's a school for conformists and it's a school that wanted children to go to Oxbridge, and if they did what they were told, the brighter half of them would be reliably transferred in that direction, and those who were non-co-operative were just left to rot, really…
I read absolutely everything I could get my hands on, from the entire - from historical fiction, Conan Doyle's historical fiction as well as Sherlock Holmes, from that to Freud, in the great books. So I read essays on psychoanalysis, when I should have been revising for my 'A' Levels!

So you're a real example of why libraries matter.

Absolutely! I mean, my entire education came from this place that's now being sold off to a posh private school… and the very fine library there, which is completely, completely dissipated. But essentially I could find any book I ever heard of, and I read it.

So what kind of Jews were you?

It was Orthopractise. My father, I never knew what my father believed, but he knew the right way to behave, and the synagogue was an Orthodox synagogue… We were strictly kosher at home, and I went to Jewish Youth Clubs, and it's difficult to remember this, but once upon a time there was a Socialist Zionist Youth Club, and I was part of the Socialist Zionist Youth Movement. I'd met my wife as part of that synagogue when I was about 14, and we're still -

still married, and living not too far from where we -

How amazing! And what did religion mean to you then, growing up? Was it identity or was it also a matter of faith?

Identity. Strong identity. Complete lack of faith… I cannot remember believing in God. I always considered myself a Rationalist. My father ran a number of consulting practises, but one of his businesses was a shop just round the corner from Carnaby Street, on Beak Street, that had scientific instruments. And he built up a fine collection of microscopes, which I've got in my flat in Oxford…
He would amuse me - my 13th birthday present was actually an 1857 microscope, and a collection of specimens on beautifully made Victorian slides, which I'd play with. I decided, then, I was going to be a scientist.

So was science the field you were most interested in?

No. Absolutely not. It was always social science.
I was recruited, as a social scientist, by a physical scientist called Isaac Asimov, who wrote wonderful popular science books, but also science fiction, and in particular he wrote one rather fine sequence of social science fiction stories… They're called *The Foundation Trilogy* originally, and it's a sequence of short, connected short stories, which is all about the collapse of the alliance across the stars because of socio-political pressures, and the civilised universal of alliance of a thousand stars is going to break down, and there was going to be ten thousand years of barbarism. But then the scientific hero, Hari Seldon, the Director of a Research Institute, had discovered the key to bringing back civilisation with not 10,000, but just 1,000 years. *The Foundation Trilogy* is about how the Foundation was set up, run initially by Seldon, and then influenced the redevelopment of the Galactic Federation. And I decided, aged 14, that my job was going to be Hari Seldon. Hari Seldon. I was going to run a Research Institute. I had absolutely no idea what that involved. It didn't occur to me that I did actually have to do my homework if this was going to happen!

But was that a book you found in the library -

Yes, I came across it. I started picking up science fiction in a second-hand bookshop,

actually, and then I started reading systematically. (1, pp 1-8)

Just quickly, on the subject of family, something I wasn't clear about last time. You say your father was the son of a Jewish immigrant from Russia who arrived in the UK on the day World War One broke out. And was conscripted into the English Army. You say "Grandfather was a watch-maker". Now, who is grandfather?

That is, that is the guy who came was a watch-maker. Essentially, very briefly the story is that he invented a timed padlock for an illegal purpose, which was off course betting, so he couldn't patent it, but he could sell it to the, frankly, gangs that were – and with the capital he raised - in England, in London, with the capital he raised from that, he bought a small jeweller's shop, and at one point in the mid-1920s, someone came into his shop, a pedlar, with a box of lenses, who said, "I'll sell this to you for £15, and throw in a couple of lessons on how to use it, use it as well". And that's how my grandfather became an optician. (3, p. 117)

2: An Influential Economics School Teacher

I also had a very interesting teacher who took us behind economics in an interesting way… First of all he taught some of the maths on the side, which I sort of understood, but also he said, "Well, look, okay, the theory says this, but, you know, it's just theory, and you actually need to think about it this way"…

His was simply to say, "Look, you need to think about the processes and mechanisms that underlie these theorems." So, for example, you have theory of comparative advantage in trade, that says a particular set of things, and he says, "Yes, okay, fine. But now think what assumptions does this make, and what are the social processes that get disrupted if you allow the theory of comparative advantage to direct your economic policy?" That's good economics teaching.

So what does get disrupted?

What gets disrupted, of course, is that people who've acquired skills historically through their

life course, find they can no longer apply those skills in the labour force because some other economic island can actually, for some reason, produce the same thing but cheaper… The theorem goes like this, that it doesn't actually matter what the absolute cost in terms of resources of producing motor cars and butter, but if you've got two islands, both of which produce motor cars and butter – and the advantage that one has in producing motor cars over butter is bigger than the advantage that the other has in producing motor cars. So it can produce three cars for each ton of butter, where the other one can only produce two cars for each ton of butter, then the countries should specialise, and that the overall product is going to be greater. Straightforward.

So the problem with that, of course, is that all the people who have butter production skills on Island No. 1 lose their jobs, and all the people who have motor car production skills on Island No. 2 lose their jobs, so the world gets richer, but, in fact, half, probably half the world gets more miserable as a consequence. Now, that's the sort of problem that comes from reductionist thinking in economics, and I was introduced to that while still at school, while still a school child. As I say, that's good economics teaching. (1, pp.8-10)

3: Into Computer-based Social Research

We were looking at, as an undergraduate, this was social policy, the literature was largely American, and it was all about rational choice and the problems of rational choice, and the way that the difficulties of calculation that are always ignored, in reductionist economic models the way that these difficulties in making the sorts of calculations that economists claimed people did, meant that you never actually had rational decision-making, you had to understand this in different ways. So I found myself doing exactly what I'd intended to do, which was applying economics to politics.

For some reason, that I can't remember, I became particularly interested in transport. In fact, I can exactly remember. I did my Master's Degree in Strathclyde, and as I said, [my teacher] Richard Rose was extraordinarily astute – he talked to me for about ten minutes about what I was going to do. He said, “Right. I think what you need to do is to write a computer simulation”. At this point I didn't know how to. I'd never actually - I knew, in principle what computer programming was, but Richard said, “Right. Okay. You're interested in this sort of theory, write a simulation of a political process”. And I learnt to write FORTRAN

programmes, which took me a few weeks.
FORTRAN, it was an early computer programming language, that you could use to do calculations. I got the book, I got the introductory manuals, and I taught myself. Both to do calculations and to draw diagrams. And you could programme the computer to produce graphs and pictures of the sort that you've seen me writing all the time…
This was voting, and I built a model of a political system where you had two Parties that had different interests, and I tried to model the process that the Parties reformulated their programmes so as to increase their their share of the vote, and I wrote a computer programme that produced an oscillation between two Parties on the basis of - and it was a smart piece of, piece of work.

And were you rather thrilled by what a computer could do?

I wasn't just thrilled, I discovered I was really good at it! So I wanted to teach, and Richard wouldn't let his first year students teach, so I got my first academic job, which was teaching computer programming to electrical engineers! Yes, frightful cheek! But the next term I was a demonstrator. I was teaching electrical engineers. At Strathclyde University. Across the road from the Politics Department, I was teaching them to write FORTRAN programmes!
I just applied. They wanted demonstrators, and I turned up. I'd done all of six or eight weeks of FORTRAN programming at this point, and they gave me a little test, and they realised I could actually do it, and it had relatively trivial skills. So I was doing a lot of programming at that point, and I was also being taught to use statistics packages…
About half way through the year, a man called Norman Nie came to visit. Norman Nie had been the research assistant on the very first comparative – serious comparative – political science project, an American project called "Civic Culture", he'd been the research assistant on this. They'd collected a four country data set. Norman Nie wrote programmes to calculate comparative statistics from the four countries that they'd conducted the surveys. This package became something called "SPSS" - Statistical Package for the Social Sciences, which was the first large, relatively easy to use – Norman Nie, I have to say, became seriously rich, doing this. Ultimately he sold SPSS to IBM for about a billion pounds! He was certainly the only sociologist I ever met who had his own private jet! But at this point, he was still writing SPSS…
So he gave, first of all he gave this wonderful seminar… What he said was, "You won't believe this, but let me tell you, the future is this. You will have, on your -" - this is in 1970 -

"You will have", said Norman Nie, "on your desk, in front of you, a computer, free-standing, that will be connected to a library of different surveys, and you'll be able to call up this library of surveys and run your analysis. If you make a mistake, you'll see immediately the result, you'll be able to correct it, and within 20 or 30 minutes, you'll have your analysis". "Wow!" we all said!

What he was actually doing was buying DAEDAL from Mark, that became the heart – and he spent, I think, £20 or £30 thousand pounds on this – Mark became seriously rich for the moment! He spent £20 or £30 thousand pounds buying this package. It then became the heart of what was called "SPSSPC" - and this was SPSS that would run on the very early personal computers that were just starting. The very first IBM personal computers were just coming. So this was a very very early connection with statistical computing, and the result of my first year at Strathclyde was that I was doing state of the art stuff. (1, pp. 12-15)

4: Operating with Punch Cards

They were 80 column punch cards. So punch cards, and what you do is, there was a machine, a card punch machine, and basically you write one line of FORTRAN, translates to 80 characters on this coded card, essentially -

And are they 0's and 1's, or are they something else?

No, the card had 12 spaces. A zero to nine (0-9), and then it was known as "plus" and "ampersand". So it had 12 spaces, and they were, in fact, designed for a Hollerith counter sorter machine. This was a machine that was built for the US Census, 1910, by an American called Herman Hollerith, and that was the very origin of statistical computing before computers – you stored data on these cards.

You would have a big tray of cards that would have 80 columns that represented the results of the survey, and you would feed them into the computer, together with some other cards that were the programme, so you put the programme in and then there's a separator card, and then you would have the data, and it would run your programme and give you a table. That was how it operated.

And what would the table look like?

The table would say, well, well, you'd have “Social Class” down the side, and “Region” along the top, and the proportion of people who voted for the Conservatives, in the cells…
I would print. It was, essentially had an alpha-numeric printer, and it was producing standard-looking tables, but using, essentially, typewriter characters.

And how long would it take to produce something?

Well, ten minutes or a week, depending…

What did it look like?

Looked like - a stack of wardrobes, large enough to fill two or three rooms of this capacious size, with vast air conditioning. There'd be one job at a time, that's why you went to the cafeteria. Your programme would go into the stack, and the operators would run programme after programme after programme.
No, you didn't get tea! No, it was known as “the cafeteria”, because it looked like a cafeteria. You queued up, you handed in, someone gave you a receipt for for the cards you'd given, and then you came back the next day and you collected your – (1, pp. 16-18)

5: The Impossibility of Completely Rational Choice

The central political science issue goes back to the reductionist nonsense that the economists have. They say you make this rational calculation, and so you find out what the complete range of possible alternatives are, and you set them against the values that you attach to different sorts of outcomes, and you choose the best. Well, the problem is that that sort of comprehensive rationality is completely completely completely impossible… Because you can't do that sort of calculation. You haven't got the data. You don't have the data, and even if you did have the data, you couldn't properly do the calculations because different people valued outcomes in different ways. I'll come on to this in just a moment, because that marks the second [problem].
But the other piece of work that I did was on the Third London Airport! Extraordinary, still going, still going on saga! But this was the early 1970s version of exactly the same, exactly

the same saga and now… But at this point there was fascinating stuff going on with a guy from the LSE [Peter Self], who wrote a wonderful article showing that if you actually took the cost benefit analysis that you were doing, seriously, and the set of values that were being fed into, the Third London Airport would actually be built on Hyde Park!

The subtitle of the article was, "Nonsense on Stilts". But essentially, the things he fed into the cost benefit model, other things came out. And so if you undervalue noise dis-amenity, and you overvalue the cost of travel time from the city centre to the airport – that's how you arrive at that's how you arrive at Hyde Park, you see. He made this point, and that was an important part of my education.

But also it became an important part of my thesis, because what I realised was that you had to go back to the economics and think about theories of social justice, and how you weigh competing preferences. In fact, you couldn't actually weigh competing preferences. You maybe arrive at what an economist might call a "rational solution", in that it maximised the total benefit to the society, but, of course, that total benefit involves imposing costs on one group of people, and benefits on another group of people. What costs are acceptable in order to justify which benefits to other people? There's no answer to that other than a political one. That was, that was what I worked out initially, to start with. But that's what my doctoral thesis ended up. (1. pp.22-3)

6: Forecasting the Future of the Electric Car

The foreground work that I was doing was for the Programmes Analysis Unit, [at the Social Policy Research Unit at Sussex University] on the electric car.

On the electric car I came up with an absolutely clear, I just went and talked to a group of people who were involved – material scientists and energy experts – and I read the technological forecasting literature in this area, and when you put it all together, it came to the fact that batteries weren't good enough unless you used a particular sort of battery that was called a "lithium sulphur battery", that would give you a cruising range of around a hundred miles. The problem with this battery was it involved having red hot sodium being pumped at a high speed one side of a semi-permeable membrane, and red hot lithium being pumped the other side of this semi-permeable membrane, for the ion exchange that goes on in batteries. And my image was a motorway pile-up of of red hot ... exactly! Exactly! So, basically, and if you did have that sort of extremely dangerous battery, which actually, when

you came down to it, if you're going to put it in a car, you would have to have so much shielding that the energy - the car wouldn't move! Exactly! Okay, so that wouldn't work…
So somewhat to the Programmes Analysis Unit's distress, one of the consequences of my first six months work there was a very very clear answer, which was – and I wrote this down – that there will be no viable electronic motor car until about the year 2000.
(1. pp. 26-7)

7: The Coming of the Post-Industrial Society and the Growth of Home-based Services

What they said was, "Look, there's this new, new book, *The Coming of the Post-Industrial Society*, Daniel Bell, very impressive, we'd like you to have a look at this. And they knew I was someone who could look critically at the stuff, and so that's what I did. And I really believed Daniel Bell..I really believed it, and what I thought I was going to do was take an incomplete empirical story, and turn it into a more complete empirical story.
Daniel Bell had talked about occupational employment, and he talked about industrial employment, and he'd shown that occupations were going to be service occupations, industry is going to service industries. Then very simply he had this thing from the 19th century German economist, Friedrich Engel, which said that - in those times it was manufacturing industry – as societies gets richer, households spend less, a smaller proportion on primary produce – food - and the larger on manufactured consumption. So that was Engel's law on the shift from primary to manufacturing consumption, and similarly so Bell said. [But] all the statistics when you looked at them showed you as richer families still spent more on service than they did on manufacturing, you didn't have technical change in service production. The barber was the issue. You always had the barber, so on one hand you had no productivity growth in services was the assumption, and you have this huge productivity growth in manufacturing. But thank God, to save us all was this Engel's law, transition to consuming more services.

And why did that save us all? Why was it a good thing?

Because what it meant was that as labour was displaced from manufacturing industry, it could

be absorbed into services in a straightforward and simple way. I believed this. That was the thesis. I believed this, and I thought, "Well, okay, what's missing here is actually looking at what households spend their money on". He hadn't done that. He'd merely taken, from the economists, who looked cross-sectionally at a survey, and you find that the richer the household is, the larger proportion of its expenditure goes on services. Straightforwardly. And I never disproved that. There's always that positive association.

However, for the first time, we were beginning to get time series of data. The very earliest UK data was from, on household expenditure was from 1952 and 1954, and by this time I had 1970, 1971 data there. Time series. That is to say we look at the same survey, but carried out with different samples in successive years. Different people, different samples of people, through, so from 1956, I think, there was an Annual Family Expenditure Survey, so you could look at this. And at this point I was just using the published tables and drawing pictures from this and using a desk calculator.

What I did simply was look at this Engel's questions, and found that whenever you looked in any of the surveys over this 20-odd year period that I had, you still found this business of people of richer households, buying more services. But when you applied a price deflator, so you got it in constant £'s, and you drew this curve, if you go back to 1954 you've got the proportion that's spent on services on the Y axis – on the up and down axis – and the wealth of the household on the X axis – on the horizontal axis - you always find an upward sloping curve, but when you, when you deflate the prices - when you use the right numbers to understand, because £20 in 1970 is the equivalent of £10 in 1960 or whatever, so you have to change the numbers to look. So when you do change the numbers, and adjust them, what you find is that while there's always a positive relationship, there's always an upward pointing, but year by year by year, that curve was shifting downwards. They bought more goods and fewer services. At each economic level, you were buying more goods and fewer services.

No one had noticed this before. As soon as you looked at it, of course, and lots of other people tested it afterwards, and you find it – wherever you look, you find this phenomenon. And the reason is, this absolutely straightforward process whereby, well, what are you buying? Economists see consumption as just **..... (?? - INAUDIBLE 76.52) -**

But they didn't see they're buying the washing machine or the -

But they didn't see the washing machine – exactly right!

Or a car.

But what you were doing, in fact, was buying something that was pretty like the capital equipment you put in factories, only instead of buying capital equipment, that's what the goods were. Instead of buying capital equipment to put in factories, you're buying capital equipment to put in your kitchen… What was going on was, instead of going to laundries – one sort of service employment – you were buying capital equipment, putting it in your kitchen, and producing clean clothes. Instead of going on public transport, you bought a motor car and you drove around in that. Instead of going to the cinema, you bought a television, and you watched the television. So you had a process of substitution that was taking economic activity from the measured economy, and putting it in the unmeasured economy.

It's actually to do with these twin processes of self-servicing and of mechanisation and subsequently automation. Automation didn't just mean reduction, mechanisation and automation didn't just mean the reduction in labour required for a given output, but also a change in the shape of the labour. So you needed more managers, more designers, more programmers, more technical people, to actually set up the mechanised production. So it was not just reduced numbers, but it was more – and this was the confusion – more service workers.

So what we found was this growth in things that I called "producer services", it was a growth in service activity, but it's service activity for other enterprises, not service activity that households were buying themselves. And this was the central error in the Bell thesis. He'd said, "We've got growth in service industries, growth in service occupations, these imply growth in consumption of services". No, it did not! It meant something different. It meant, "This is the technicisation of the more and more involvement of technology in material production".

It was his conclusion that service driven by final service consumption would grow – that was what was wrong. And, in fact, one of the nicest illustrations of this was shopping, where you had this move from a fully serviced, or at least, a partially serviced model: so I would, in the 1950s, in my caricature, you go to the corner shop, you put your head round, you say, "Hello, Mr. Jones. Could I have the usual", and then you'd walk on, and Mr. Jones says, "Oh yes, it's, I'll put it in the box", give it to Johnny, who puts it on his bicycle and cycles it round, and you pick it up. Okay. 1950's, growth of supermarkets, and change in the transport system.

Instead of walking to your corner shop, you get in your car and you drive to the car park of your supermarket. You walk to the supermarket, you walk up and down the lines doing that job that Mr. Jones used to do. You queue, you pay, you take your [goods]. So a huge decline in the number of service, of final service workers for people providing those retail services, and an increase, presumably, of activity outside the economy, of people doing those transport and warehousing functions, where the supermarkets were like wholesale warehouses previously.

And had anyone seen this before?

I was probably the first to spot this systematic, I was certainly the first to write-up this… But basically that was my, that was my invention. To Daniel Bell, *The Coming of Post-Industrial Society*.

And did he respond to your findings?

He responded beautifully! I actually went to a SPRU 50 year Reunion, and one of my old friends there says, "I remember, I was organising the seminar, the seminar series in 1978, and I remember you giving the first version, and I remember pasting together the overhead transparencies and photocopying them, and presenting them, and there was Daniel Bell, who was doing a visiting stint at the LSE". And we my old friend, Howie, remembers this to-ing, to-ing and fro-ing of argument between me and, and, and Daniel Bell. Who became, who became a friend. Yes, he bought it. He bought it entirely… You know, I was a kid, and he was very very famous, so he responded magnificently, he would introduce me to all sorts of people, and he – (1, pp. 28-33)

8: Time Use Diaries, the Mass Observation Archive and the BBC Archives

At the same time I started to discover that people had been doing large-scale diary research. I discovered, first of all, **Zandh Zeller's (?? - sp. - 88.12)** big book that was just published that year, called, *The Use of Time*. It was a cross-national comparative study, 1973. It is 12 countries, half Eastern Europe, half West Bloc, not including the UK. So that had just come

out. The date on this is 1972, but I only came on it at this point. This is built on diaries - surveys, time use diaries. There's a long history that goes back to the beginning of the 20th century, I won't take you through that! But, so this was the first cross-national comparative data set. It had America, France, two Germanys, Italy, Belgium, a couple of other Western countries, and then Hungary, Bulgaria, Russia, East Germany.

Then I discovered the Mass Observation Archive, down the hill in Sussex! At Sussex, you know, in the library! And I walked in, and said, "I'm looking for diary evidence", and the nice young lady who was just unpacking the boxes of the Mass Observation Archive that was just starting up, she said, "Oh, we've got something like that". She pulled out this, this box - and basically, she pulled out, from the table, these rotting away bits of paper where people had written down details of - They were rotting away. So the first thing they had to do was to, was to retrieve -

Well, it hadn't been archived, they'd just acquired it. This Dorothy [Sheridan], her first job was actually to conserve this stuff, so it was all set in plastic. In the end we did actually acquire, 500 or 1000 diary days from Mass Observation. So suddenly, Mass Observation, there was 1930s stuff.

I discovered that the first British time-use survey had been carried out in Liverpool, as part of the Social Survey of Liverpool, and the name on the chapter in the book about the Social Survey, was a C. Saunders, and one floor above me in Sussex, was a very eminent previous Director of the United Nations Economic Commission on Europe, a certain Chris Saunders, and I knocked on his door, and I said, "Chris, do you know anything about this?" And he said, "Oh Yes, that was my first job! I remember that!"

Then I started to talk to my immediate boss in Sussex, a very eminent psychologist called Marie Yahoda, who had written with Lazarsfeld, who is a founding father of empirical sociology in the States, while they were still both in Austria, and were a couple at that time. They'd written an absolutely epochal book called, *Die Arbeitloser von Marienthal – The Unemployed People of Marienthal*. I was showing Marie this stuff, she said, "Oh yes, I collected those time-use diaries back in Marienthal", she said. And I think this is probably the first I ever heard of Marienthal at this point. And then I discovered that the BBC Audience Survey Department had been collecting things called "Viewer/Listener Availability Survey".

That amazed me when I read about that. Why did the BBC do that?

Well, they wanted to know who's going to listen.

And how they much they listened, and when they listened.

But this was the very first, this is audience, audience research…
One of the very first things I did was, I went to the BBC, I went to the Beeb, and talked to the Head of Audience Research there – Brian Emmet – and Emmet said, "Oh, you're talking about time budget research". And I thought, "Oh! Am I?" And he said, "Well, yes, and actually, the world expert on time budgets is working with us", John P. Robinson, who had actually been the research assistant on the Use of Time Project, who had actually written the programmes to produce the huge tables and pictures at the back… So I was introduced. John was actually there, not doing time use, but doing interesting stuff on how news was understood. He was … doing a year's sabbatical in London, based at the BBC Audience Research Department.
I met him there, and in fact, it was he and I together, that went to the basement of the Beeb, which at this time was in the Langham Hotel - you know, the Langham was the Beeb's Staff Club, and the Audience Research Department was there, and in the basement they had a dump, and just material was left there. And we were told, "Well, somewhere down there, there are these surveys". So we went down, John and I, and we spent days and days just turning over stuff in these store rooms in the basement. Eventually we found the whole of the 1961 Time-Use Survey, in a set of egg boxes and tea chests.
Egg, you know, the big - I mean it was, I suppose, two foot by 18 inch boxes, that had had egg cartons in them, and was filled up with these diaries – 3,500 diaries. Just the diaries. Whole week diaries, with no clue as to who the respondents were, apart from a column of figures on the front page. And I have a modest example here.

How amazing! How beautiful!

There's the, there's the original -

And the serial, 2022221, is that the person's identifying -

Exactly. That's the person's identifying thing. So the first thing we did was, the Beeb was a rather bureaucratic organisation, so I took executive action. I hired a white van, and I drove it

up underneath the portico, and as imperiously as I could manage, I said to the porter, “Could you give me a hand, please, I need to move -”, and so, and so we got, we got -

It's like Guy Fawkes, he got people to carry the gunpowder for him -

This is exactly what I did! I got them to carry the boxes for me, put them into the white van, and I drove it down to, drove my stolen -

Fantastic!

And the first thing that I did with my research assistant, Graham Thomas - by this time I had my doctorate, and he was a junior, but he was a very very smart programmer. The first thing he did, was type these columns of numbers that identified the respondents. And then we got frequency distributions from those numbers and worked out which number meant which characteristic, social class, age, age group.

How did you work that out?

JG: Well, we knew from the published tables from 1961, how many men and women there were, and how many in each social class, and at each educational level. Once we'd got the frequency distributions from that column, we could simply compare them and that, so we'd identified these.

Brilliant. Can I see, can I see the -

Yes, yes. This, this is the very first, and frankly, very crude, time use-diary.

Gosh! How beautiful. So 16th April to 22nd April, 1961.

And, you see, people have written in great detail, everything that they were doing. It's a half hourly record....
Now, of course, these are much too crude. It should be done with five minute intervals, and you need to say – they cram in all the things they're doing into one activity – but what you need to do is to say, “Were you doing anything else at the same time?” And, “Who were you

with?" And, "Where were you?" And the modern diaries actually have other columns as well, like, "How much did you enjoy it?" And the one we've just collected this year, has, "Were you using an electronic device while you were doing it?" So we'll get wonderful results.

"Cleaned goldfish bowl". I love that! That doesn't come very often! "While listening to morning music".

That's right. While listening, so there's two activities there. So she's doing pet care as the primary activity – and she's listening to the radio. So then I, so I discovered this, and I wrote my first ever research proposal to the Research Council saying, "I want a lump of money so I can code this 1961 data up, and compare it with the 1976 Survey that the BBC have just – (1, pp. 34-9)

9: The First Transistors

But then, at SPRU, at this time, we were being introduced to the very start of the micro-electronics revolution, and I remember going to a seminar given by the research director of Fairchild Electronics. Fairchild Electronics who had actually invented some of the first transistors, and then they'd worked out that you could not - that what you were doing was making transistors out of blocks of crystals, separating them, and then connecting them back together again on a printed circuit board; and then they worked out, in Fairchild, that you didn't need to do that. If you printed it properly on the crystal, it could make a little computer chip…

He told this wonderful story about when they first had transistors they didn't know what to do with them, and he talked about a delegation coming from some Japanese company who wanted to buy tens of thousands of these transistors that they'd read about in the technical literature. And they held their breath and gave them a good price, and then, and they were sort of nudging each other as they saw the delegation back on to the aeroplane, and one of them finally said, "Mr. Sony, without loss of generality, what are you going to do with all these transistors?" And he said, "Ah! I make small radio". And apparently they'd gone back in the car to their headquarters, laughing among themselves, making racist comments about, "Oh, small radios for small people!"

Because it was the beginning of - and he told this story against himself, and he said, "We're in a similar sort of position with these new integrated circuits, we don't know quite what's going

to happen". And suddenly there, at the end of the seventies, in SPRU, we started thinking about what you did with these integrated circuits, and how they could transform, and what you could use them for, and getting small - the very first personal computers, for example, and that's when the *Social Innovation* book came. That's where the idea of social innovation came from. (1, p. 41)

10: Forecasting Transistor Radios and Internet Shopping

What I realised in that 1983 *Social Innovation* book, was that exactly the same thing was going to happen with computers, and I came up – this is my second set of technological forecasts, which wasn't quite right, because I got the timing wrong. But what I said was, "What's going to happen is that", of course, we didn't have the internet, but we did have broadband switch telecommunications networks, and we had good Japanese intelligence at this time, and I knew that the Japanese were investing in broadband with switch telecommunications, and we put two and two together, and assumed that their Ministry of International Trade - that was the technical place - was making the same sorts of judgements that we were, and that we were reading from the French Plan: that what was going to happen was that people were going to buy services down the lines. So I came up with a whole lot of things like teleshopping, and I had "subscription opera" was my example. We had lots of good ideas, and suddenly people were quite excited about this.

The thing I was really struck by, the heating and lighting systems that you would be able to control yourself - which is what happened…You had the TV subscription service, armchair shopping, but I thought the fact that you talked about systems for heating and lighting, that's spot on.

JG: Well, thank you, I'd entirely forgotten that! Well, what had happened was… Richard Layard had written an article in the seventies, about the economics of the Open University, and I read that, and I suddenly realised what was going. This was then the very simple economics that lay behind my social innovation model, which was, instead of going for labour, for high unit cost/low investment services, you went for high capital investment/high fixed costs, very low unit cost production of services. You know, entirely simple and obvious, so just as in the Open University, you use the domestic technology, and you had

software which was, in effect, the television programmes that were broadcast, and exactly the Open University was the model for this generation of innovation.

Weren't you saying that to have economic growth, you'd have to support the self-service economy, and you'd have to have services that would support people doing things themselves?

Exactly. So, exactly so. It's infrastructure that was the requirement to allow this new process. Now, what I got wrong was, I said, "And what's more, this is the economic miracle of the next ten years". But it wasn't…

Tell me, you said you thought it was an unpleasant development, because firstly there'd be unemployment, and secondly, isolation.

That was my original thought. It was just displacing labour, and I couldn't see where the new jobs were coming from. The orthodox Austrian economics had said there's "creative displacement", and Schumpeter talks about "animal spirits generating new employment to replace the old employment". I just couldn't see where it was coming from. But I took it seriously… Its new forms of provision for needs that had previously, for needs, some of it outside the economy – outside the money economy…

But what I wondered was, did people pay attention to what you wrote?

No. No.

No. Did you think they would?

I knew it was important, but not many other people did, I'm afraid!

But was that not distressing?

I was sufficiently self-confident - and I knew there was a long way to go, because we needed theory that's not there yet, that looks properly at how time is used. I hope that by the end of

my career, I will have produced that. (1, pp.42-5)

11: The "Big Society"

So are policy-makers, do they pay attention to some of this?

So, suddenly, suddenly it's starting… We had a false start about five years ago, with David Cameron's "Big Society" nonsense, and the Cabinet Office caught on to us here. Well, the problem is that the "Big Society" is not very big at all. When you actually do the arithmetic, and what we did was then, we got a message from the Cabinet Office very very early on, in the Cabinet saying, "Would you please tell us how big the 'Big Society' is?" And we did these calculations and we said, **"Well, ... (INAUDIBLE – 119.09)**

Meaning what, the "Big Society"? People volunteering?

The "Big Society", people volunteering, doing things for households outside their own… It's tiny, tiny, tiny. What we discovered was, depending on how you defined it, somewhere between seven and 15 minutes per day, across the population. I think about 1440 minutes in the day, maximum 15 minutes, so it comes down to less than 1 per cent of the day.

I was talking to a friend about this, about the fact that my generation does far less volunteering and all these things, she thought it was because women work. Is that true?

Yes. That's it, basically. (1, pp.46-7)

12: On Acadedmic Rivalries

There were some people who, frankly, intentionally misunderstood when I talked about informal economy. They suggested that I meant that this was somehow free-standing and independent of the rest, and that was never my idea. It was a sort of constructed misunderstanding that academics – I've done it too, you know, you exploit someone's

marginal unclarity in order to produce the motivation for your next article. (1, pp. 49-50)

13: Theory and Reality in the Domestic Division of Labour

At the time that my son, Asher, had just been born, John [Robinson] came over and we sat for about two days solidly, in the the study in my house outside Bath, writing an article that subsequently appeared in *Demography*, that showed that women were doing less domestic work, and men were doing more domestic work.

But men still did a lot less!

Exactly. Did a lot less, exactly!

So this is 1970?

So John and I sat in this office, and my wife, who by this time was actually working at Harwell, but she was taking some sort of maternity leave that she'd partly finished, and she had a small son. John and I were sitting there for 24 hours, and she was bringing us in food, and she said, "Well, what are you guys finding?" And we said, "Well, we've discovered that things are all changed in the household . You know, men are doing more", and Esther said, "Out! Go!" (1, p. 50)

14: On Human Capital

The structural bit. We normally think of structural characteristics, as being maybe your social class, or well, the amount of – if we go back to this horrible word – "human capital" you've got or whatever. Whereas, actually, the right way to think about it, and this is why the development of human capital, something like capabilities or capacities is the right way to think about it, rather than having these fixed structural - you do things, and by doing those things you learn to do those things well, which then become your capability at the activity, which determines your access to participation in those activities in the future. And it works just the same way in your workplace. The more reliably and properly you work in your

workplace, the more you build up your capacities, and probably more important, your employer's view of your capacities -

That's why you said that people who put in overtime get more promotion. Is it that kind of thing?...

Actually, there's a dynamic of formation and accumulation of characteristics through the life course, and these characteristics are formulated, in effect, through the things that you do. You know, at some point they may be quite discreet things, you know, passing exams, but mostly it's accumulating characteristics.

So it's not because of your class, it's because of what you do.

It's what you do. Of course, it's highly correlated with class, because you're brought up in a particular household that could be thought of as having a class position. This is what Pierre Bourdieu, in *Distinction*, that you start off by acquiring these almost native characteristics, the capabilities that are associated with your household of origin, and then you acquire more characteristics from your formal educational system and from your peers, and those various capabilities, which are not just at work – that's what economic capital, "human capital" is what the economists call it -- economic capital, but also cultural capital. So for example, the more you go to concerts, the more you know how to enjoy concerts, and the more likely you are to go to a concert once you're familiar with that sort of music.

But what about the fact, the more you do housework, doesn't mean you actually know how to do housework - you don't get better at doing housework -

No, you don't… The extent of learning is probably rather limited in that case, but in cultural capital the extent of learning is not limited. I'm not happy, terribly, about these distinctions, because they turn into one another. In the book that I've been writing forever, I talk about how, just as Bourdieu gives the example about how different sorts of capitals can be exchanged, I got the example of the steam train driver who becomes unemployed in 1965, but who by 1975 is the doyen of the Steam Trust, and whose daughter becomes the General Manager of the Steam Trust. So you get economic capabilities being translated into leisure capabilities, back into – sports is a very good example of that interplay – so your practices

through the day determine the sort of person you are too. (1, pp. 53-5)

15: Changing Gender Divisions

But where, of course, it's really important, is in gender divisions. Essentially what you can get out studies like British Household Panel Study, and understanding society, is there's a very precise picture of the consequences of alternative couple strategies about work and employment over time, in the relative wages of the husband and the wife. So what I developed, I had this nice name "Allerednic" - have you come across "Allerednic"?

No! No!

If you listen very carefully, you'll realise that "Allerednic" is "Cinderella" backwards! "Allerednic" is this well-known fairy tale about the prince who marries a princess and turns her into a chambermaid! So what happens is the boys and girls do exactly the same, and the girl gets a slightly better job than her future husband does. They marry, they have children, she drops out. He stays in, works harder, he goes up and she goes down, that's the story of the gender wage gap – simple as that. It's not the workplace. Okay, it used to be the workplace. That workplace discrimination has gone, now it's straightforwardly in the home, and that's what we do. (1, p. 55)

16: Climbing Greasy Academic Poles

Did you like being head of [Sociology at Bath]? Did you? (LAUGHS)

I liked – exactly! I had fun, you know, running Examiners' Meetings. I thought, apart from my combination of aphasia and face-blindness that occasionally – and actually, this is quite important for me because, when I said, "Now, am I going to become a Vice-Chancellor?" I said, "No. Look, the people who do it really well remember all their colleagues, and I don't want to be saying, 'Oh, Professor, Professor -

Did you cause offence by mistake?

I doubtless did. I mean, I would always excuse myself. But I've always been in the position with people that I work with regularly, if I'm in a stressful situation, I'll forget the name. So that was a component in my decision. That was the negative bit of the decision not to go on up the greasy academic pole.
Subsequently when I was starting to be offered Vice-Chancellorships when I was in Essex already, Ivor Crewe actually critically made the difference for me. He said something very wise. He said, "Jay, are you ambitious?" And I said, "Yes, I'm very ambitious". He said, "Yes. But, look, you are not academically ambitious, you're intellectually ambitious". I'd never understood that. But that's right. That's right. I was ambitious because I want to do some real academic work - some real academic work as opposed to achieve high academic status. (2, pp. 62-3)

17: Originality Generating Enemies

Because, you've been doing quite unconventional things haven't you, so does that attract enemies?

Exactly. It attracts enemies, particularly among people who don't do particularly, frankly, innovative stuff. People with big reputations for doing essentially normal science, do resent people who get any sort of reputation doing anything, however small, doing anything unconventional.

And is this because you're often challenging their findings?

Sometimes. But sometimes it's just giving offence by not doing it the way it ought to be done.
(2, p. 64)

18: The Evolution of the British Household Panel Study

So let's go back a tiny bit. Tell me about the whole idea behind the British Household Panel Survey.

I think I've already said something about the Research Selectivity Exercise that was the beginning of the Research Assessment Exercise. The Exercise is now carried out by the University Finance Committee, but then it was the University Grants Committee, and they decided to work out which universities were doing well at which subjects. They had a grand inquisition in the mid-eighties where they looked at each subject in each university and scored it. And Essex Social Sciences came out really well. They came out top in Economics and Politics, and Sociology… They decided, very wisely, because this was a really rather nice university – at least, at that time – that they would do two things with the extra money they got out of doing well, out of the Research Selectivity Exercise. First of all they'd support weak Departments to help them improve, but most important, they would push the money back into strong Departments to make them stronger still.

There was a decision too, there was an interesting interdisciplinary area to be explored in the area of household behaviour, and they set up the Household Research Project, which was thinking about new directions for Essex research to go in, and it was an interdisciplinary project between Politics, Economics and Sociology. They called in, to lead it, a sociologist from the University of Kent, Ray Pahl, who's someone that I'd worked with in the past. He led this household research project that was partly funded, in fact, by this extra money that the University had earned, and partly from Unilever Research. There's a Leverhulme Research Charity that funds research,..

Ray had a very talented group of people to work with, in particular an economist, a tax economist, weirdly, called Tony Shorrocks, who was very interested in income distribution, and well understood the work that Ray and I had been doing in the previous decade on the relationship between formal economic activity and informal economic activity… And Ray was solidly inside this household [issue], trying to understand, to arrive at a new understanding of economics through household behaviour. He found allies in the Economics Department, in particular this guy Tony Shorrocks.

But you understood that, from Tony Shorrocks' point of view, it was households and not individuals that provide well-being, and you have to understand, if you're going to understand income distribution, it's the distribution of household income that's important. But more than just the cross-sectional distribution of this income, but also how permanent this income was.

It was another part of the work that we'd been doing with Ray on Sheppey... We understood that it was not merely what you earned now, this week, but actually how that fits into the whole life course of earnings and, and accumulation of capabilities of various sorts. And that,

of course, fed directly into the idea of a Household Panel Study. Now, what we'd been doing up to this point in the UK, were retrospective studies. So we'd take a group of people and we'd get them to recall what their life has been up to this point. Very useful stuff, but, of course… But here's the problem with retrospective. Not recall, obviously you forget stuff – but much more important, I think, than recall biases, is something called "survivor bias".

That is to say you've got to live until this point, in order to give your work history! So that if you look incautiously at retrospective data, you find that coal mining is among the most healthy sorts of, sorts of occupation! Because the ones who aren't supremely fit are dead! … And it was well-understood by this point, that if you weren't going to do life course stuff seriously, you had to get round this survivor bias, which meant that you collected not retrospective data, but prospective data. And current. It's as it happens, but then you collect it as it happens.

Now, the drawback with this, of course, is you have to wait for it to happen. It's lovely now, because we've got getting on for 30 waves of the British Household Panel Study in addition to the retrospective data. So we did collect the retrospective data early on, but what we've got now is prospective data for the whole, for more than a generation of people now – and I'll come back to the design of the Household Panel in a moment – but what we were doing was building on some experience. We weren't the first. Some experience that was already available from the States first of all, and then from Germany…

Anyway, so this was the fascination of panel studies long before I ever got to do panel studies. And the States started doing them quite early, first of all doing work on the negative income tax. Enormously progressive. Sponsored by Edward Kennedy in 1968. There was a large-scale negative income tax experiment, where just they paid a negative income tax – that is to say that if you earned less than a certain amount, then you were actually paid out of the tax system rather than paid into the tax system, so you have no poverty trap, and you have a guaranteed minimum income…

Unfortunately this sample didn't carry on very long, because the first unequivocal result that came out of this was a really hugely positive result, it was that women in abusive relationships were able, on this basis, to escape from those relationships. They were able actually to move out. They had the resources to, and they would have a period in which they didn't need to get the first job that came along. Okay. This is the first published result from this. But, of course, Edward Kennedy was he then the Junior Senator for Boston? Or maybe, yes, with a strong Catholic [presence], so in other words, suddenly the support for negative income, as an utterly perverse result of this, that disappeared…

And then did you say Germany had something?

And then Germany said, "Okay. Now there's a bit of a problem with the Panel Study of Income Dynamics, because you've got individuals, but you don't have information about the household that surrounds those individuals, because all you're getting is proxy reports". PSID, by this time, was trying to understand income dynamics, looking at the incomes of all the people in the household that it was asking, no one responded.

So the next stage in this was the German Socio-Economic Panel, which started up in the early to mid eighties, which decided to adopt a different technique randomly sampling households, talking to all the adult members of those households, and also to the natural descendants of those households. So as the children of the household aged in to 16 – I think was the starting point for the survey, as it was for the BHPS – as they aged in to the sample, then you'd start interviewing them. Wwhat that meant was that as people died off at the top end, there's young people coming in. So what you actually had was a sample that reproduced itself naturally – the way normal populations do – and would carry on being, could be carried on, would remain for a long time representative subject to the problems of attrition…

In fact I was on the Advisory Committee and quite involved in the design from the start, because for one thing, it was my [field]. It was also my friend, Ray Pahl, who was running this. I was a bit more of a statistical boffin than Ray was, so I got involved in it from that point of view. And also I'd been doing the retrospective life course stuff, so I was very interested in it. So I was engaged in it right from the start… But, of course, I was relatively junior and Ray was relatively senior. There wasn't any serious elbow there, but I was very happy to contribute.

The other people who were important in this, driving this forward, oddly enough, was the political scientist, Ivor Crewe, who was the, eventually the Pro-Vice Chancellor of Research, and then the Vice-Chancellor of Essex. He actually acted as the first Director of this thing that got funded – the Research Centre for Micro-Social Change. The Research Centre for Micro-Social Change, that's what's got funded in Mrs. Thatcher's **[time]**, surprisingly extended by Raiza Gorbachova's insistence that sociologists shouldn't be excluded from the competition for large-scale funding. Essex put in this proposal from Ray, Ivor Crewe, David Rose, **..... (INAUDIBLE – 23.14)** and so on -

And how did this body connect to the British Household Panel?

Well, the Research Centre for Micro-Social Change was what was funded by the ESRC to run the British Household Panel Study… It was initially almost interchangeably "Survey" and "Study", depending on who was talking about which aspect. "Survey" obviously referred to the actual data that was being collected, but for the first few years there was no data, so "Study" was the operative word. The first couple of years were devoted to very serious committees meeting with members from across the UK and with international members to decide on exactly what should be in the survey, and also how it should be organised. There are these two models – the PSID and the German SOEP. The Socio-Economic Panel, that stands for. The idea was to produce the absolute definitive version. Unlike so much of British science policy, we weren't first, but we wanted to be best. And that's what they did. I mean, I have to say that we took on all the improvements that the Socio-Economic Panel made on the Panel Study of Income Dynamics, learnt all the lessons, and also did some other things better than the Socio-Economic Panel did, so the actual data preparation provision, and provision data quality was much higher and it was much easier to use.

It took years to plan. The first thing that happened was a Steering Committee, a Central Steering Committee was set up, and it decided what sub-groups it was going to have, and there were these sub-groups and they met over months and there was a period -

Sub-groups looking at what kind of thing?

At income measures and at domestic division of labour measures, and at attitude and preference measures and political identification. All the different things you'd use the Household Panel Study for, across many different disciplines were actually coped for by groups. There would be meetings every few months of the sub-groups, and also of the Central Steering Committee. After, I guess it was about 18 months, a survey emerged that would have taken three to five hours to administer for each, for each person to be [interviewed]. Then there's another process of cutting it back and compromising. So in the end no one was satisfied with it, but it was a very well-designed survey covering a huge range, and with a huge number of potential applications. I think it probably took three years to get into the field, which is not a terribly extended time, and I think it's an appropriate time to get it right.

There was a pilot survey that went into the field about nine months before the main survey, and that pilot sample was kept on for two or three, three years, I think.,, Then you have a very good data documentation, which meant that if you had a problem to solve, and you came new

to the data, you'd sit down at lunchtime, and you'd get your results by teatime, where my view was if you use the PSID, you sit down at lunchtime and get your results by Christmas! (LAUGHTER) So it was brilliant, and it was beautifully done. Very well prepared.

But, of course, that meant that after three years, nothing had come out, and there were people who were specialising in criticising social scientists as being essentially wasteful. I'll mention one in particular, because he's still in the public, and that is David Walker, who, where Polly Toynbee has written a number of really very good books, but he's also written recently a critique of the ESRC. He talks about lack of policy relevance of research carried out by the Economic and Social Research Council and its predecessors, and I think he's misguided. I think that he mistakes short-termism for policy relevance, and he assumes that everything that the social scientist does has to be policy relevant. Whenever I read what he is writing in this vein, I agree with the substantive social science to a considerable degree, but when I read what he's writing in this vein, I want to produce – is it Humphrey Davy who, in the British Institution in some time like 1820, gives this demonstration with sparks and so on, and at the end of the lecture some old biddy comes up to him and says, "Mr. Davy, could you explain to me, what use is your electricity?" And Davy says, "Madam, what use is a baby?" (3, pp. 67-77)

19: Levels of Physical Activity

Levels of physical activity are terribly important nowadays because we've got this thing called the "obesity epidemic", which is traceable to two sources. One is eating, and the other is exercise. And the exercise is not well studied at all. In order to work out how much exercise people get, people fill out something called a "Physical Activity Questionnaire". There's an international Physical Activity Questionnaire, which is a standard battery of 20-odd questions where you say, "In the last week, how often did you do so and so?" "How often did you go to the gym?" "How long do you go for a run?"

Now, we can actually check on the reliability of these by comparing it with our "Random Days Diaries". So we've got Random Day Diaries, and then we've got the same respondents answering these PAQ type questions. So we don't do it by the week, we do it by the month. We say, "In the last month, how many times have you gone swimming, gone to the gym, gone for a walk", and so on and so forth. Now, what's interesting about this is that if they say, for example, "15 times in the last month", we know that there's a probability above .5 that, on a

random day, they will go for a walk, okay? So what you do is simply take the group of people who say, “We do it, we did it 15 times last month”, and predict, “Well, they should have a probability in excess of .5”, and then you look at the randomly chosen days that they got, you find that .2 of them -

So they're lying?

They're lying - well, no, they're misrepresenting. And it's actually well understood that people do misrepresent. It's not just social desirability bias, there's also a thing called “identity bias”, and there's other processes, but they all lead to a systematic misrepresentation. (3, p. 78)

20: What Matters Most

So do you think really the thing to say is that what matters is that the findings are in public access to your data?

Absolutely.

That's the key thing. To make it worthwhile and usable and worth the money.

Absolutely. Now obviously this is not to say you collect information about absolutely everything all the time. We don't know what's going to be useful, but we have hunches that particular sorts of things are going to be of considerable importance, so we knew, back in the eighties, that the domestic division of labour was important in some sort of moral way. Well now we know that it's absolutely crucial to understand the gender wage gap, and this is a major public policy issue, and this is something that can now be operated on. We now know that this is the case. We just had scientists with hunches making discoveries.

You need serious long-term findings. Obviously it's got to be serious, and by serious I mean properly based on previous theoretical arguments. By based on, I don't mean repeating them, and I do mean very often arguing with them, at least responding to people who have thought seriously about these things in the past, thinking about these things. Then measuring them,

and making your measurements available to other people to use is the key to all this. (3, pp. 79-80)

21: BHPS: The Sample and Interviewing Adults and Children

Well, the absolutely crucial point is that you have to maintain your sample over time. It's no use if 20% of the sample drop out each year. In the first year you will lose 20% of your sample, but the next year it's got to be half that, and the year after that it's got to be a quarter of that.

And how do you stop people dropping out?

By pursuing them. Well, we gave them Boots vouchers, £5 and then it went up to £10 I think. We gave them Boots vouchers, but that wasn't why they stayed in. We tried to make the survey interesting, positive, something they wanted to get involved in, and once they were in, we then pursued people ruthlessly. We had a Unit in the basement of the building called, euphemistically, "The Refusals Conversion Unit"! It was actually run by an ex-Chief Inspector from Essex Police, I think (LAUGHS) whose job was, to put no too finer point on it, harass people who'd said they didn't want to take part. So, I mean it wasn't done too ruthlessly, and if anyone complained, we would apologise and send them complementary vouchers and so on and so forth. But the big problem was actually getting them to talk to us again…

It was a national random sample. It was multi-stage, nationwide. The original sample was south of the Caledonian Canal – if you know where the Caledonian Canal is! So basically it's more sheep than people north of the Caledonian Canal, so we didn't sample there, but it was UK, initially not including Northern Ireland, but England, Wales, and Scotland south of the Caledonian Canal. To save money, what we did was have a multi-stage sample where we'd sample regions, and then much smaller regions within those regions, and then have a cluster initially of people essentially in the same four digit postcode, so that interviewers could go to those places and interview lots of people.

It was all done by interviewers. And those interviewers talked to absolutely everyone in the household. So we tried to get complete household interviews. There was a household

interview where "an informant" gave information about the household, the household's membership, and various characteristics of the members, and attributes of the householders as a whole. Then we got everyone in the household to fill in an individual questionnaire. Later we got the children, aged between 12 and 15, to fill in a questionnaire.

So what was the interviewer, and what was questionnaire?

Well, the interviewers were administering a fixed questionnaire, it was very carefully designed. They were asking the questions, people responding.
Except in the case of the children's questionnaire, where there was, for this time, a really nicely designed system, designed by Jackie Scott, who was the Research Director there, she's now a Professor of Sociology in Cambridge. Jackie Scott designed this nice system. While the parents were being interviewed, being asked questions by the interviewers, there was a tape-recorder, and the children had a numbered answered sheet, and there were questions being asked on the tape-recorder, and the children wrote their answers on the numbered sheet, so that the parents didn't know what they were saying. So we could ask somewhat intrusive questions about the children, which they greatly enjoyed! And, of course, these children were going to be recruited over the next four years, one to four years, into the main sample, so this was another way of maintaining high levels of response.
And indeed we did manage very high levels of response. We got down to a 94% or 95% response rate by the end, which was as good as anyone has ever managed. (3, pp. 80-2)

So how did a household first discover they were being targeted?

They would get a, they'd get a letter, nicely designed, through the door, "Would you be interested?", and then there'd be follow-up telephone calls.

And so who was doing all of this? Who were your interviewers?

NOP – National Opinion Polls. NOP had not done this work before. We had to work really hard to keep them up to scratch because they were mostly used to doing quota surveys, not random sampled. We had a brilliant guy running it – Nick Moon–… and he did really very well in terms of understanding what was needed, delivering on time, meeting our peculiar requirements, which included, for example, that wherever possible the same interviewer went

back to the same household.
What it means is that there were individual bonds with the interviewers, they then became almost [friends]. That's one of the mechanisms that we got very high response rates.

And why were the households willing to do it? What was in it, I mean, why did they agree?

Ah! At one extreme, public duty, you know. We did say, "Look, this is an important thing. We're going to discover" - and they would realise quite soon they were asking important questions. And quite early on various public bodies started using us and acknowledging that there, so all the way through the nineties, there's more and more stuff in, for example, the annual publication *Social Trends*, that came out of the BHPS, so anything that was vaguely longitudinal came out of the BHPS. And we got some rather interesting findings… (3, pp. 80-3)

21: Changing Gender Roles and Work in Germany

The work we're doing with it at the moment, is looking at how earnings respond in the long-term to long-term histories of employment, and in particular how husbands activities contribute to wives economic performance and vice-versa. So obviously we've got a hypothesis that if husbands do more work at home and more childcare, that sets the wife free to be more engaged in work, which means that her income goes up. We couldn't actually look at those sorts of long-term interactions between family care and economic activity unless you've got very detailed information about all the activities being done by all the household members, over a very long period in time.

And is this because you're finding husbands are doing more of this, or is this to get public policy to encourage them to do more?

Both! Both! What we find is that where husbands do more of this, the wife benefits, and that's an empirical observation. Then we can say, "If you do more of this, then there'll be more effect", and, in fact, at this point, comparative research comes into it. So with **my student Lara Lamla** who's worked on the German Socio-Economic Panel over a very very long period, Lara has found one particular policy works very well, which is flexibilisation,

flexibility that allows parental leave to be taken flexibly both by the husband and by the wife, over quite an extended period after the birth of the child. What she found in her doctoral thesis is that, in fact, it's not just that the husband taking up a flexible work improves the wife's work chances, but also the wife's work chances improve the husband's long-term, long-term work chances.

How is that?

Well, actually, that very last bit I'm slightly sceptical of. What you can do, you see the real problem here is, is it a particular sort of person who does these things, and if it is a particular sort of person who does these things, then you can't tell whether it's doing those things, or being that particular sort of person.

If you're the husband who cares about your wife's career and well-being, you might also be the one -

Be the sort of person who's actually going to do very well indeed…

So they already do it somewhere in Scandinavia, we always read about how advanced, how progressive they are. Sweden -.

Oh yes, they are. They're much better, we've data. Finland is the country that's done it for the longest, and they found great difficulty actually persuading the husbands to take it up. And then they said, "Okay, if the husband doesn't take his half, the couple loses that half", and that seemed to have a really serious effect. (3, pp. 86-8)

22: Qualitative or Quantitative

I said "Yes" too quickly when you said "It's all quantitative research", because I think that that distinction between "quali" and "quanti" is something that is felt more by quali researchers than quanti researchers, that actually, much of what we do, as quantitative researchers, is intensely qualitative… The time-use stuff actually gets people to use their own words to explain what they're doing in their daily lives, and that's quali material, not

quanti. We make quantitative use of that qualitative material. But that's what quali researchers always do. Because ultimately, okay, you want to talk to a person and explain what that person is thinking, feeling, and try to understand why, but as soon as you've got not one person but five people, you eventually end up making quanti statements. "Three out of the five said this, two out of the five said the other". And as soon as you've got -

So what does "quantitative" mean?

I don't want to get too deeply into this, because I'm possibly a bit prejudiced about it – but my feeling is that there's an unhealthy trend in British sociology that has rejected quantitative research in favour of quali research for unworthy reasons. Now, I, of course, understand, that trying to understand what people are doing and saying in a properly, in a properly qualitative way, is the essence of any serious social science. But I then want to generalise from that qualitative understanding to understand what's going on among different social groups and in the population as a whole.

So within the field, what does it actually mean – qualitative and quantitative? Which one's which?

Quali means small-scale. It means structure for discussion rather than predefined questionnaires. [Quantitative] means limited categorised answers as against extended discursive explanations. The qualitative takes small samples. The samples are, at best, structured purposive, stratified, but very often simply convenient samples, you know, you just grab the first person you find and ask them questions. So the sampling is not such that you can easily make generalisations, and the questioning follows a less, a less predetermined course than quanti does. And that the answers to the questions are more discursive and less specific. With the result that it becomes difficult to generalise from the rich descriptions that you undoubtedly get from qualitative research.

And quantitative, in my experience, is surveys, isn't it?

It means surveys or other sorts of structured instruments, for academics – with representative samples that are normally probability samples.

And the BHPS, surely is that, given that it had survey questionnaires?

It is definitely quanti, but various people use it very appropriately for quali purposes. That's to say, each time we talk to the people we say, "Would you mind if we got back in touch with you? If we put someone in touch with you to do this or that?" And various quali researchers come to us to say, "I would like to talk to a group of people who have step-children", for example. And we can identify a group of people who have step-children, and we find out which among those people have said they are willing to be contacted for these purposes, and then we take a random group of those. So then we get quali research done on a sample that we can then place precisely, and it's that combination of quanti and quali that is real serious social science. (3, pp. 92-3)

23: Computer-Aided Personal Interviewing

Now that carried on until about 2000, where we made the transition from paper questionnaire, from personal interviews and paper questionnaires, to personal interviews and computer, and computer-aided questionnaires. We did this Computer-Aided Personal Interviewing – CAPI. So they went to the houses with their laptops. They fill it in as the person goes, and one of the great advantages of this is that you can have a lot of feed forward - the jargon is "dependent interviewing". So you can say, very easily here, "Now, last time, when we asked you this question, you said you were doing this and that. Has that changed?" Or "Last time we asked your opinion, do you feel differently about it now?" So it's very helpful. It makes it smoother, and it makes connections, because sometimes, when we've got something wrong, we can actually correct retrospectively. They say, "No, I wasn't in that job when you last spoke to me" - you got that wrong!

Pressed the wrong button!

Exactly. (3, p. 94)

24: The Millennium Birth Cohort

So that I remember getting a, a call, some time in February 2000, from the Cabinet office saying, “Mr. Brown has decided that there's going to be a Millennium Birth Cohort, and would you please have a press release for, for issue at midday?” Of course, this was the first we'd heard of this! And my first reaction was, “No way!” because I know it takes a couple of years to get things going. In fact, the compromise was that we did have a few people who were interviewed right at the end of 2000, having got this Millennium Birth Cohort under way, and it is actually working very well.
(3, p. 96)

25: Key Findings: Work Won’t Disappear

The most key findings are to do with work. The real surprise – this is the really extraordinary thing that comes out for us - is that work doesn't disappear. That Keynes was absolutely wrong in talking about the consequences of economic change for our grandchildren – that famous 1924 lecture, 1930-odd - he said to his original audience, “You haven't heard this word before, but mark my word, 'technological unemployment'”. Because technology, he said, “Well, in fact, there'll be less and less work to be shared round”.

And that's what we're saying now again, isn't it?

Look. He wasn't the first person to say this. He was saying this because, actually, his father, who was also called Maynard Keynes, said it in his economics textbook 20 years before! But his father said it because he'd read it in John Stuart-Mills, *Principles of Political Economy*, in 1848, where John Stuart-Mills, said, “Well, look, actually, we're a rich society now. Within a generation we can meet all our needs, and everyone can - and work time will get shorter and shorter, and we escape from the realm of necessity”.

We'll all be gentlemen!

We'll all be gentlemen! Well, exactly that! And that was the thought process. But, in fact, Keynes was better at this than he thought, because if you read this essay, it's called “The Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren”, it's actually got two parts, and one of them is to do with this technological progress that he talks about – that means less and less labour to

produce what's needed to keep us. But then the second part, he says, “Well, look, this sends up a bit of a problem”. He imagines, now – and it's sexist and classist and so on – but he produces a Music Hall song about about an old charwoman who's now got nothing to do. She's superannuated, she's got nothing to do except -”, and then he makes a joke about listening to the radio as “the choirs of Heavenly angels”, he says. But what he's doing, he's talking about what other people then started to call “the problem of leisure”. If you're educated for work, and suddenly there's no work for you to do, what do you actually do with your life?

This comes back to - certainly I realised this came back to this theme 30 years before that my teacher, Marie Jahoda, had introduced me to - which she got from looking at her unemployed people in Marianthal in the 1930s. Which is that when work goes away, much of the meaning of life disappears, because you need rhythm and exercise and social context and purpose, and something to get you up in the morning. And, okay, so what you now get when you look at this data set, is a picture that when you define work broadly enough to include unpaid work, using the third person criteria - this is something you could pay someone else to do for you – but once you look at work in that way, you actually find it doesn't reduce very much. Paid work went down for men between, say, the fifties and the eighties, paid work time went down, but during that time, women were doing more and more paid work while carrying on doing all the housework and everything else. And new work-like tasks emerged -

Like what?

Well, looking after your children. Suddenly you find you're - or looking after your parents, because they live longer, so you're looking after your parents, and you're looking after your children, and suddenly economists are telling you that you've got to invest in your children so that they can improve their human capital. And then it's not just that they say they want to go to judo, but they have to go to judo so they've got something to write on their university application form. So suddenly you've got the sort of defensive time expenditure generating your children's CVs and protecting them from all those rapists and murderers that are suddenly out there…

Disraeli back in 1870-something, had a Factories Act that limited the working [week] of male manufacturing workers to 60 hours. And when you add up paid and unpaid, and if you actually look at all the different things you call work now, well the working week is about 55, 60 hours.

In total, you can find when you look at properly organised surveys, husbands and their wives tend to work rather similar totals of time, paid and unpaid. But nevertheless, the men are doing a whole lot more paid and women are doing a whole lot more unpaid, and that's what drives the gender wage gap. (3, pp. 104-7)

26: New Diary-collecting Based on GPS

We're doing, oh yes, we're doing all sorts of different diary research. The first big thing that we did was, was a GPS, GPS-GSM thing, where we actually got people to carry around a little match-box that had a GPS and a telephone chip.

That tracks them all?

It tracked them through the day, and sent exactly where they were, to our computer in Oxford. Then it downloaded the GPS track, and we wrote all sorts of clever software to map it on to Google Maps – this now all happens in I-phones, and you can do it simply, but at this point no one was doing it. So we got this Google Map that said, "at this time you're here, and at that time you're there", and then we constructed a time-use interview that was based on that map. We downloaded that to them wherever they were, and had this automated interview that read the map and said, "Well -"

"What were you doing in Budgens?" or something!

Exactly! But before that, it said, "Well, we first saw you on your doorstep at such and such a time, could you tell us everything you did from the time you woke up until you got to there. Then you're travelling from here to Budgens, could you tell us how you travelled, what was your mode of transport? And then at Budgens, what were you doing at Budgens?" "What were you doing at this location, until you came, where did you go next?" So we got 1300 days of data that way. That was our first. We knew new ways were coming. Did this in 2011 and 2012. We experimented with mobile phone apps and, and simple diaries on laptops, in a couple of different places. So we've got a nine country survey using laptop interviews that we collected last year.

On the Millennium Cohort, we actually got all the children to keep a diary either on a laptop

or on their telephones. We did that last year, and we're just starting to work on this. And most recently, and most excitingly, we have a validation study that I'm writing up today and tomorrow, which is comparing three sources – a written diary of the traditional paper sort; an accelerometer, a wrist-worn accelerometer; and a wearable camera. The wearable camera takes a photograph every 45 seconds or so, and producing about two and a half thousand images a day. And basically my colleagues go through and produce a diary interpreting these pictures. Very intensive. It's hugely expensive. It's a wonderful research tool for all sorts of purposes, so if you're looking, for example, at eating, you get much better pictures of eating using that, but it's not a practical research tool for most purposes.

But what you find, the reason we're doing this, is an extraordinary convergence between the diary and the camera, and the accelerometer. Basically it validates the diary methodology. What it does, if you take a 33-activity breakdown of the activities of the day, of those 33 activities, three have differences in the camera and the diary of more than about five minutes in aggregate. So you're getting the right estimates from the time-use…

But no audio yet? You haven't been - because for the sleep, they were recording on their phone.

No. We don't use that method. (3. pp, 108-110)

27: No Retirement?

What does your wife think of you being there for another ten years?

She is appalled! She is appalled! She's horrified! She's going to retire in August, and she buys it that I'm not actually going to retire. But hopefully the pattern will change, and maybe I'll get something out in five years, not ten. Indeed, I fully intend to.

But my model here is Mr. Mercator. He, he of the projection, who, of course, invented the atlas. In fact, the atlas is called an atlas because the very first of them was produced by Mr. Mercator and his sons, and it had on its frontispiece, Atlas bearing the world, and that's why they've been called "Atlas" ever [since]. He was dead for six months when his atlas was published, and he was 86! And, in fact, it was his sons who produced – unfortunately my children haven't followed me, so I'll have to be a bit, a bit quicker than that! But I've set

myself the same sort of task. What he did was essentially collect places. The atlas was constructed because he identified eight or ten thousand places with latitude and longitude. Yes, that, precisely latitude and longitude, and that was how he was able to produce his atlas. And what I've been doing is producing – that's what my 75 and growing surveys from across the world are all about. (3, p. 113)